

THE STORY OF RUTH

Your God will be my God

1 During the time of the Judges, there was a famine in the land of Judah. Elimelech left Bethlehem with his wife, Naomi, and their two sons, Mahlon and Chilion, to live in Moab. After settling there, Elimelech died. Later, Mahlon and Chilion married Moabite women named Orpah and Ruth. About ten years later, both sons also died, leaving Naomi without her husband and sons. When Naomi heard that the famine in Judah had ended, she decided to return home. Her daughters-in-law went with her, but Naomi urged them to stay in Moab. She said, *"Go back, each of you, to your mother's house. May Yahweh be kind to you. Return home, my daughters. Why should you come with me? I have no more sons to become your husbands."* The women wept. Orpah kissed Naomi goodbye and returned home, but Ruth refused to leave. Naomi said, *"Look, your sister-in-law has returned to her people and her gods. You too must return."* But Ruth answered, *"Don't ask me to leave you. Where you go, I will go, and where you stay, I will stay. Your people will be my people, and your God my God. Where you die, I will die and be buried. May Yahweh deal with me severely if anything except death separates us."* Seeing Ruth's determination, Naomi stopped urging her. Together they traveled to Bethlehem. When they arrived, the people recognized Naomi, but she said, *"Don't call me Naomi. Call me Mara, for Yahweh has made my life bitter. I left full, but Yahweh has brought me back empty."* Naomi and Ruth arrived in Bethlehem just as the barley harvest was beginning.

Ruth gleanes in the field of Boaz

2 Naomi had a wealthy kinsman, Boaz, of the clan of Elimelech. Ruth said to Naomi, *"Let me go to the fields and glean behind the harvesters in the field of one who will show me favor."* Naomi answered, *"Go ahead, my daughter."* As it happened, Ruth came to the field of Boaz. When Boaz arrived, he greeted the harvesters, *"Yahweh be with you."* They replied, *"Yahweh bless you."* Boaz asked the foreman, *"To whom does this young woman belong?"* The foreman answered, *"She is the Moabite who returned with Naomi. She has been gleaning behind the harvesters since morning."* Boaz said to Ruth, *"Do not glean in another field. Stay here with my maidservants. Follow after the harvesters. I have commanded the young men not to molest you. When you are thirsty, drink from the jars they have filled."* Ruth bowed and said, *"Why have I found favor in your eyes, though I am a foreigner?"* Boaz answered, *"I have been told all that you have done for your mother-in-law. May Yahweh reward you, under whose wings you have come for refuge."* At mealtime, Boaz invited Ruth to eat. Then he instructed his young men, *"Let her glean even among the sheaves, and do not reproach her. Pull out some stalks for her to gather."* Ruth gleaned until evening and brought the barley to Naomi. Naomi asked, *"Where did you glean today? Blessed be the man who took notice of*

you." Ruth replied, *"The name of the man is Boaz."* Naomi said, *"Blessed be Yahweh! This man is our close kinsman, one who has the right of redemption over us."* Ruth continued to glean with the maidservants of Boaz until the end of the barley and wheat harvests while living with Naomi.

She went and lay down at his feet

3 Naomi said to Ruth, *"My daughter, should I not seek a home for you? Boaz, with whose maidservants you have worked, is our close kinsman. Tonight he will be at the threshing floor winnowing barley. Wash, perfume yourself, put on your best clothes, and go there. Do not make yourself known to him until he has finished eating and drinking. When he lies down, uncover his feet and lie there. He will tell you what to do."* Ruth replied, *"I will do all that you say."* Ruth went to the threshing floor and did as Naomi instructed. At midnight Boaz awoke and found a woman lying at his feet. He asked, *"Who are you?"* She answered, *"I am Ruth, your servant. Spread the corner of your cloak over me, for you are a kinsman who has the right of redemption over me."* Boaz said, *"May Yahweh bless you, my daughter. Do not fear. I will do all that you ask, for everyone knows you are a worthy woman. It is true that I am a close relative, but there is another who is nearer than I. Stay here tonight. If he will redeem you, let him do so; but if not, as surely as Yahweh lives, I will redeem you."* Before dawn, Boaz said, *"Let it not be known that a woman came to the threshing floor."* He filled Ruth's mantle with six measures of barley and sent her home. When Ruth returned, Naomi asked, *"How did you fare, my daughter?"* Ruth told her all that Boaz had done and said, *"He gave me these six measures of barley, saying I must not return to you empty-handed."* Naomi replied, *"Wait, my daughter, until you learn how the matter turns out, for the man will not rest until he has settled it today."*

The Levirate law

4 Boaz went to the town gate and sat there. When the kinsman who had the right of redemption passed by, Boaz called him to sit down. He also gathered ten elders of the city as witnesses. Boaz said, *"Naomi, who has returned from Moab, is selling the land that belonged to our brother Elimelech. As the nearest kinsman, you have the first right to redeem it. But if you will not, tell me, for I am next after you."* The man replied, *"I will redeem it."* Then Boaz said, *"On the day you redeem the land, you must also take Ruth the Moabite, the widow of Mahlon, to preserve the name of the dead through his inheritance."* The man answered, *"Then I cannot redeem it, lest I endanger my own inheritance. Redeem it yourself."* According to the custom in Israel, the man took off his sandal and gave it to Boaz, confirming the right of redemption. Boaz said to the elders and the people, *"You are witnesses this day that I have bought from Naomi all that belonged to Elimelech, Chilion, and Mahlon. I also take Ruth the Moabite as my wife, to preserve the name of the dead through his inheritance."* The elders answered, *"We are witnesses. May Yahweh make the woman coming into your house like Rachel and*

Leah, who built up the house of Israel. May your house become like that of Perez, whom Tamar bore to Judah."

Obed was the father of Jesse, who was David's father

So, Ruth was taken by Boaz and became his wife. Yahweh made her conceive and give birth to a son. The women said to Naomi, *"Blessed be Yahweh who was provided you today with an heir. May he become famous in Israel! He will be your comfort and stay in your old age, for he is born of a daughter-in-law who loves you and as worth more than seven sons."* Naomi took the child as her own and became his nurse. And the women of the neighbor gave him his name, saying, *"A son has been born for Naomi."* They named him Obed. He was the father of Jesse, who was David's father.